CHAPTER 3 The Tool: Active Love The Higher Force: Outflow

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Subject	CHAPTER 3 The Tool: Active Love The Higher Force: Outflow
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Internal

THE MAZE

You're so trapped in hurt and anger that you can't move on. Everyone gets into this state, even people who think of themselves as calm and rational. All it takes is the right stimulus. It might be triggered by someone close to you, who can hurt you with a look or a negative tone. But it could just as easily be a neighbor's loud music or a friend's political opinions. We call this state "the Maze." It's called the Maze because the deeper you get into it, the harder it is to escape. The person who has "wronged" you becomes your obsession. It's as if they've taken up residence in your head and you can't get them out. You curse them, you argue with them, you plot revenge. In this state, the other person becomes your jailor, trapping you in a maze of your own repetitive thoughts.

Take a moment right now and choose a person who triggers this state in you. Then try this exercise:
Close your eyes and visualize the other person provoking you. React to this intensely, as if it's really happening. What are you thinking, and how does it make you feel? Note to yourself that this is a distinct state of mind.

You may be justified in reacting the way you do—*but it doesn't matter.* Once you're in the Maze, you're damaging yourself.

But the Maze is a threat to all relationships, not just marriage, because it warps your view of people. When you're in the Maze, you literally forget everything good about the other person—all you can think about is the wrong he's committed. The Maze doesn't just damage your relationship to other people; it damages your relationship to life itself.

When you're in the Maze, life passes you by.

Most wrongs that people commit cause no lasting damage; if you were to let go of the initial hurt, you could go on with life immediately. But you don't. You obsess about what was done to you in the past. As a result, you turn your back on your own future. The most frustrating thing about the Maze is that even after someone can see what it's cost them, they still find it impossible to escape. The rage, revenge fantasies, and hurt feelings had a momentum of their own.

FAIRNESS

Why is it so hard to get out of the Maze?

We're trapped because of a universal human expectation that the world will treat us fairly. This is a cherished, childish assumption—"If I'm good, the world will be good to me." We should know better—the world violates this assumption every day. Someone cuts you off on the highway, a customer is rude to you. But despite this overwhelming evidence, we cling to our childish views. As long as you insist that life treat you fairly, when someone wrongs you you'll demand that the scales of justice be balanced immediately. You'll dig in your heels and refuse to budge until this happens. This is why the Maze almost always involves fantasies of revenge or restitution. You're engaged in a futile attempt to restore fairness to your world. Most of the time you're unaware of this expectation that people will treat you fairly. But it's there, in the background—which means that, at any moment, you're standing right outside the mouth of the Maze, primed and ready to be swallowed up. All it takes is some injustice—any injustice—and before you have time to think, you're trapped and can't get out.

THE HIGHER FORCE: OUTFLOW

It's not easy to give up your childish expectation of fairness. In my experience, it's only when you feel something bigger, better, and more powerful than fairness that you stop waiting for it. The trick to getting out of the Maze is to generate a form of love that's independent of your immediate reactions. After all, your reactions put you in the Maze in the first place. That's love in its higher form. We have a name for this kind of love: "Outflow." *Outflow is an infinite, spiritual force that gives of itself without restraint.* It's like sunlight, shining equally on everything and everyone. The moment you feel this force, you're lifted above your petty hurt feelings. You no longer need a remedy from the offending person because Outflow is its own reward. Unlike fairness, it's a reward that has real value. It lets you go on with your life.

Please be clear: tapping into Outflow doesn't mean giving in or being passive in the face of wrongdoing. We're not counseling that you roll over and let people mistreat you. Outflow changes your *inner* state; in an *outer* sense you're still free to respond however you want to. In fact, you'll find that by tapping into this higher force, you'll be free to be *more aggressive* should you choose to confront someone. As long as you're in the Maze, you still need something from the person who wronged you. This gives that person an intimidating power over you. In Outflow, connected to a higher force, there's no one to be afraid of.

THE TOOL: ACTIVE LOVE

Think of Outflow as a huge tidal wave of bountiful energy, bestowing itself on the world. Although it surrounds you at all times, you can't perceive it until you're in a giving state yourself. You have to be in sync with Outflow just like a surfer has to be in sync with a wave he wants to ride. When you give from the heart, you let yourself be carried by Outflow the same way a surfer does when he paddles forward to catch a wave. The trick is putting yourself in that state whenever you choose, especially when you're so hurt or angry it feels impossible. You have to make a conscious effort to generate love when someone has just wronged you. For most of us this feels unnatural. Like children, we expect love to be effortless. Part of growing up spiritually is understanding that it takes work to be truly loving.

For most of us it's not natural to work at love—we need a tool. The tool is called "Active Love" exactly because it combines love and effort. The work you do when you use the tool creates a miniature flow of love inside you. That puts you in sync with a larger, universal wave of cosmic Outflow. You should use Active Love whenever someone incites, enrages, or otherwise provokes you to enter the Maze. It's a reliable way of tapping into Outflow. You'll now have the power to free yourself from the Maze in any circumstances. No one will be able to put your life on hold.

Active Love

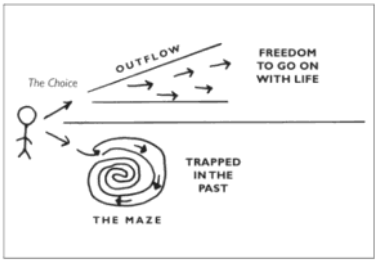
> **Active Love**
>
> Imagine that you're surrounded by a warm, liquid light that is infinitely loving. Feel your heart expand far beyond you to become one with this love. As you bring your heart back to normal size, this infinite energy concentrates itself inside your chest. It's an unstoppably loving force that wants to give itself away.
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> Focus on the person who's triggered your anger. If they're not physically in front of you (usually they're not) then visualize their presence. Send all the love in your chest directly to them; hold nothing back. It's like completely expelling a deep breath.
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> Follow the love as it leaves your chest. When it enters the other person at their solar plexus, don't just watch. *Feel* it enter. This will give you the sense you're completely at one with them. Now relax—you'll feel yourself again surrounded by infinite love, which will return to you all the energy you gave away. You'll feel filled up and at peace.

Each of the three steps has a name to help you remember it.

- The first step is called "concentration." You're gathering up all the love that surrounds you and concentrating it in your heart—which is the only organ that can find it and hold it.
- The second step is called "transmission." In this step your heart functions as a conduit, transmitting love from a higher place into this world.
- The real power of the tool is in the third step, which is called "penetration." When you *feel* the love you're transmitting enter the other person, there's a sense of total acceptance; an acceptance that comes only with the experience of oneness. This is a victory—you've embraced injustice completely and are free to move on from it. With this new power, no one has the power to put you in the Maze. No one can stop you.

This ability to be free of the effect of others even applies when you don't know who the other person is. The classic example of this is when somebody cuts you off on the freeway and you can't identify who he is. It also applies to whole organizations, like the post office or the Department of Motor Vehicles. The beauty of the tool is that you need not know who you're angry at—you're using the tool for

yourself. It takes nothing away from the power of the tool if you have to imagine what the person or persons look like. You'll probably find yourself doing it naturally. What matters is that you have a figure, real or imagined, to pour your love into. It's that act that sets you free.



The stick figure is you, the moment after you've experienced an injustice. The lower arrow indicates that you do nothing; in effect, you've chosen to enter the Maze. The upper arrow indicates that you've chosen to put yourself through the three steps of Active Love. This decision unites you with Outflow; you're free to move into the future. Many patients visualize this picture when injured to remind themselves they do have a choice.

HOW TO USE ACTIVE LOVE

Practice the three steps right now—concentration, transmission, penetration. Go through them over and over again so that you can use the tool from memory. You should get to the point where you can run through the three steps quickly but with intensity. The most obvious cue for Active Love comes when someone does something to you that makes you angry: it could be anything from your son failing to take out the garbage to a colleague stealing your idea. Typically, you'll overreact. Your anger is either disproportionate, or you just can't let go of it; probably both. The cue is anger: the moment you feel it, use Active Love and keep using it until you regain your perspective and move on.

The second cue relates to a less-obvious kind of anger, which is just as frequent. This anger isn't caused by anything that's happening in the present. You're reacting to the memory of something done to you weeks or years ago. If you allow a memory to put you in the Maze, that's just as damaging as being put there by something that just happened. We all have a powerful tendency to ruminate on past injustices. In the midst of an otherwise great day, you'll find yourself remembering someone who snubbed you at a wedding or a colleague who tried to undermine you with your boss. It's at that moment you have to use Active Love.

Finally, Active Love can be used as a way of preparing yourself to deal with difficult people. Each of us knows at least one or two people who are so offensive we go into the Maze at the very thought of them. The classic figure from comedy is the mother-in-law, but it could be your spouse, your child, or your boss. When we anticipate run-ins with these people, we waste a lot of time worrying about how they'll treat us and how we'll react. This doesn't prepare us for the interaction, it's just another version of the Maze. The only real way to prepare yourself for these encounters is to use Active Love. In fact, you should use it whenever you think of these difficult people. As a result, they'll take up less space in your head. Once you can get out of the Maze at will, they won't have so much power over you and you'll deal with them much more confidently.

You'll find working with this higher form of love more rewarding than working with any other substance. When you give away love, you end up with more than you had when you began. Unlike water, if your glass is half-filled with love and you give it to your enemy to drink, the glass will return to you full. That's the reason you feel filled up and at peace in the final step of Active Love.
When you use the tools, you're rewarded with much more energy than you put in. There's only one explanation for this: the tools allow you to experience the infinite energy of higher forces. Active Love gives you a good example of this. You give away all your energy, but when you're finished, you have more than you started with. That's why your half-filled glass is always returned full. This is an immediate experience of the infinite.

For most people, Active Love creates a new model of confrontation. Use the tool *before* you say anything to the other person, even before you're in his presence; keep using it until you can feel yourself go into an Outflow state. Once you're in this state, you're ready to confront the other person. It will allow you to be assertive without being provocative. It may seem strange to use love as a preparation for confrontation. Try it with an open mind and observe what really happens.

OTHER USES OF ACTIVE LOVE

Active Love builds self-control. *Nothing is more destructive for you and those around you than a temper you can't control. The only way to rein this in is to have a tool that works right in the moment, defusing the bomb before it explodes.*
Active Love lets you be more assertive. *Nothing is more frustrating than being angry at someone and feeling unable to express it. The more the anger builds up, the more dangerous the confrontation seems. A tool that defuses your anger makes it safe for you to assert yourself.*
Active Love trains you to accept others as they are. *Everyone in your life is imperfect, either because of something they've done in the past or something they can't change in the present. Fixating on these things destroys relationships. You need a tool that allows you to accept people despite their flaws.*

SUMMARY OF ACTIVE LOVE

What the Tool Is For

When someone enrages you and you can't get the person out of your head. You may replay what he or she did or fantasize about getting revenge. This is the Maze. It puts your life on hold while the world moves forward without you.

What You're Fighting Against

The childish belief that people will treat you "fairly." You refuse to move forward with life until the wrong you experienced is rectified. Since that rarely happens, you're trapped.

Cues to Use the Tool

1. Use Active Love the moment someone does something that angers you.
2. Use it when you find yourself reliving a personal injustice whether it was in the recent or distant past.
3. Use it to prepare yourself to confront a difficult person.

The Tool in Brief

1. Concentration: Feel your heart expand to encompass the world of infinite love surrounding you. When your heart contracts back to normal size, it concentrates all this love inside your chest.
2. Transmission: Send all the love from your chest to the other person, holding nothing back.
3. Penetration: When the love enters the other person, don't just watch, *feel* it enter; sense a oneness with him or her. Then relax, and you'll feel all the energy you gave away returned to you.

The Higher Force You're Using

Active Love creates Outflow. Outflow is the force that accepts everything as it is. This dissolves your sense of unfairness so you can give without reservation. Once you're in that state, nothing can make you withdraw. You are the chief beneficiary; you become unstoppable.